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"We constantly keep a close tab on the dynamic and rapidly changing electronics markets to track the emerging trends and anticipate which components are relevant to the Indian market. Another important channel that allows us to keep pace with component demands in India is through the element14 online community. The online community provides engineers with a platform to interact with their peers and discuss about the latest trends within the different electronics sectors. This provides us information on the technologies that are increasingly important to engineers, thus allowing us to stock up our inventory with relevant solutions before the demand spikes. Apart from this, we keep

working with our main suppliers and take their inputs on the components in demand in the region, as well as the new products they want to introduce in India to drive their design activity funnel," says Pagar.

"We interview a wide section of the industry. Based on the demand from the design and development and R&D teams, we search for the components in China, Taiwan and many other countries across the world. Then we do extensive sampling for the customer and after that the final product is zeroed in. So the component selection is absolutely customer-driven," says Shah.

The components that work in China or the US, may not work here. For instance, "Mains supply voltage fluctuates widely (in India). If you look at CFLs, these have to withstand a voltage range of 130-300V. If you go to China or Europe, there are no voltage fluctuations," explains Shah.

"We select the components per customers' specifications and requirements. We also consider their end applications to suggest the right devices," informs Ravikumar.

Major handicaps

The engineers today use the latest technology to design new products, which means use of more and more high-end components like field-programmable gate arrays, very large-scale integration devices and sensors. Unfortunately, the Indian distributors lack the technical and financial ability to cater to the needs of this growing demand. They still concentrate on transistors and triacs.

Another noticeable trend is that, "Customers are hesitant to forecast for long-term production planning due to soft market and the US dollar appreciation," says Rathindra Kumar (Rathin), business unit head (semiconductor division)-India, Yosun India.

Most distributors have no technical background and lack infrastructure like proper storage, handling and packaging system. Many of them look to make a fast buck by selling cheap and substandard components. This is



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